



The many battles of Vinesh Phogat

Despite the **demands** of Olympic preparation, Vinesh Phogat has learned to balance on and off-mat challenges.

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Vinesh Phogat stands at a critical juncture in more ways than one. The only Indian woman wrestler to land two World Championships medals returned to competitive wrestling at the National Championships in Jaipur in February following a knee surgery

in August last year. With the Paris Olympics only five months away, 29-year-old Vinesh is running against time to regain her peak form to challenge a much younger Antim Panghal, who has secured the quota in women's freestyle 53kg event.

Vinesh, who took on former Wrestling Federation of India (WFI) president Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh for several improprieties, including sexual harassment, is unsure about

Triumphant return: Sakshi Malik presents the gold medal to Vinesh Phogat after her win in the 55kg category at the 2023 Senior National Wrestling Championships in Jaipur. SHASHISHEKHAR KASHYAP

the course of their battle against perceived injustices.

But her priority is regaining full fitness after starting serious training in December.

Given her impressive track record as a two-time Olympian and two-time Worlds bronze medallist, winning a National title might not seem significant. However, her mental insecurity, possibly stemming from the uncertainty of her comeback, was